

SUCCESS SKILL: SELF-DIRECTED LEARNING

BACKGROUND

This rubric is aligned to the [NCIES literature review](#) on self-directed learning. The value proposition is a clear research-based definition of self-directed learning as a success skill. This research-based rubric¹ is designed to provide useful, formative information that teachers can use to guide instruction and provide feedback to students and students can use to reflect on the quality of their self-directed learning. Student performance is described along a continuum and balances content-specific and the more general nature of critical thinking. Rubrics are provided by grade span, K-2, 3-5, and 6-12. The K-2 rubric includes both a teacher version and a version for primary students or early readers. Highlights from the National Center for Assessment's Literature Review are provided below. The research-based definition, identified in the literature review describes self-directed learning as...

“...a complex construct that includes cognitive, interpersonal, and intrapersonal skills, including:

- **Self-Regulation:** an ability to plan, direct, and control one's emotions, thoughts and behaviors during the learning task.
- **Motivation:** the desire or obligation to engage. Growth mindset is a significant factor related to intrinsic motivation. A growth mindset is defined as: believing that intelligence, personality, and abilities are flexible and dynamic, shaped by experience, and changing over the life span.
- **Personal Responsibility:** a willingness to take responsibility for one's actions and demonstrate behaviors aligned with clear principles.
- **Autonomy:** an ability to recognize available choices and take charge of one's learning and engage in ongoing reflection and evaluation” (2020, pgs. 4-5).

BUILDING SELF-DIRECTED LEARNING THROUGH CULTURALLY-RESPONSIVE GOLD STANDARD PBL.

- Use Gold Standard Design Elements and Project Based Teaching Practice to support students as they develop self-directed learning skills.
 - o [Gold Standard Design Elements](#)
 - **Voice & Choice:** Projects allow students to make their voices heard; make choices about what they investigate, the products they created, and how they work and use time with guidance from the teacher as appropriate. [Read more](#) about best practices.
 - **Critique & Revision:** Students give, receive, and use feedback to improve their process and product. [Protocols](#) support students in the feedback process.
 - **Sustained Inquiry:** Students engage in a rigorous, extended process of asking questions, finding resources, and applying information.
 - **Reflection:** Students [reflect](#) on the effectiveness of their inquiry and project activities, the quality of the work, and obstacles and how to overcome them.
 - o [Gold Standard Project Based Teaching Practices](#)
 - **Build the Culture:** Teachers explicitly and implicitly promote student independence and growth, open-ended inquiry, team spirit, and attention to quality. One example is the creation and use of [classroom norms](#).
 - **Engage and Coach:** Teachers engage students in their learning and work alongside them, to identify when they need skill-building, redirection, encouragement, and celebration. A culturally responsive classroom is based on learning partnerships, balances support and push, and cultivates a positive mindset and sense of self-efficacy. ([Hammond, 2013](#)).
 - o **Review and pilot test the criteria in these rubrics in local contexts.** This will ensure that they accurately reflect how students across sociocultural contexts and conditions demonstrate self-directed learning (Brandt, 2020). While [PBL supports culturally responsive teaching practices](#), it is important to note that while assessing the quality of self-directed learning cultural differences must be considered. Some differences are verbal, other differences are non-verbal and mediate what is considered “appropriate” task management. Verbal and non-verbal interactions may vary across cultural contexts. Teachers should also know their own cultural lens and recognize how that may influence the interpretation of culturally and linguistically diverse student learning behaviors ([Hammond, 2013](#)).

UNDERSTANDING THE LINK BETWEEN SELF-DIRECTED LEARNING AND COLLABORATION. Research studies demonstrate that personal responsibility and autonomy were fostered through collaboration, working in groups, and seeking help from peers or teachers (NRC, 2012). For additional information on building collaboration through Gold Standard PBL, please review our Collaboration Rubrics.

These rubrics were created by National Center for Improvement of Educational Assessment (Center for Assessment) in collaboration with PBLWorks. This version of the rubric integrates asset-based language based on the *Ready for Rigor: A Framework for Culturally Responsive Teaching* (Hammond, 2013).



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Self-Directed Learning: Grade K-2

Self-directed learning occurs when a student demonstrates self-regulation, autonomy, motivation, and personal responsibility.

DIMENSION				
	<i>Select the column where most of the criteria describe what a student knows and can do independently.</i>			
	BEGINNING	EMERGING	DEVELOPING	DEMONSTRATING
Self-Regulation	- Goals are set by the teacher. - Demonstrates difficulty initiating and completing learning tasks. - Demonstrates frustration during unfamiliar or challenging learning tasks, which stalls the learning. - Engages in reflection about the project activities.	- Collaborates with the teacher to set goals. - Focuses on getting work done with little self-monitoring. - Recognizes frustration and stays focused with the teacher's help during unfamiliar or challenging learning tasks. - Engages in reflection about their inquiry and project activities.	- Independently sets goals, seeking consult with the teacher if needed. - Focuses on getting work done using aspects of self-monitoring. - Manages frustration with minimal help from the teacher during unfamiliar or challenging learning tasks. - Engages in reflection about their inquiry and project activities, and the quality of the work.	- Independently sets ambitious yet attainable learning goals, in keeping with learning expectations. - Completes assignments on time using feedback from self and others to adjust and make improvements during the learning process. - Uses strategies to overcome frustration during unfamiliar or challenging learning tasks. - Engages in reflection about their inquiry and project activities, the quality of the work, and obstacles and how they overcame them.
Autonomy	Completes learning tasks as directed by the teacher.	Manages learning tasks with assistance or redirection from the teacher.	Makes choices and manages learning tasks with minimal redirection from the teacher.	Makes choices and manages learning tasks independently.
Growth Mindset	- Sticks to work that is familiar. - Gives up on tasks that are new or challenging. - Receives feedback about their work.	- Is willing to take on challenging or new tasks when prompted. - Frequently asks for help when faced with a challenging problem. - Requests feedback about their work.	- Is willing to take on challenging or new tasks. - Attempts to solve challenging problems before asking for help. - Utilizes feedback about their work to continue to develop/refine their work.	- Embraces challenging tasks as a learning opportunity. - Attempts to solve challenging problems using strategies or resources, seeks help or guidance only after attempting to solve a problem independently. - Utilizes feedback about their work to continue to develop/refine their work or processes. - Provides constructive feedback to others.
Personal Responsibility	- Makes choices often focused on their own needs and wants. - Demonstrates limited awareness of the consequences associated with a given set of actions on self, others, and/or the environment.	- Recognizes that personal choices affect others. - Recognizes there may be consequences associated with a given set of actions on self, others, and/or the environment.	- Makes choices based on self and others' well-being and/or interests. - Recognizes and accepts the consequences associated with a given set of actions on self, others, and/or the environment.	- Advocates for and makes choices based on self and others' well-being or interests. - Anticipates the potential consequences associated with a given set of actions on self, others, and/or the environment to inform decisions.



EXAMPLE Self-Directed Learning Grade K-2 *For Students*

DIMENSION				
	<i>Show what you know and can do independently.</i>			
	BEGINNING	EMERGING	DEVELOPING	DEMONSTRATING
How do I engage in the work?	- I usually take direction from my teacher. - I don't always start or finish my work on time. - I get frustrated and stop working. - At the end, I reflect on the tasks.	- My teacher and I set my goals. - I complete my work but do not revise it. - I get frustrated but work through it with help from my teacher. - I reflect on the tasks and how I complete them.	- I set my own goals and check in with my teacher. - I complete my work and make revisions or changes before it is finished. - I work through frustration with only a little bit of help from my teacher. - I reflect on the strategies I use and the quality of my work.	- I set challenging goals that match my teacher's learning targets. I complete my work using my own feedback and feedback from others to improve it. - I use strategies that I learned to manage my frustration when the work is hard. - I reflect on the strategies I use, the quality of my work, and how I work through challenges.
Am I making good choices?	My teacher makes most of the choices.	I make some choices with help from my teacher.	I make many choices and ask for help when I need it.	I make most of the learning choices on my own.
Do I stay with the learning when it is hard?	- I work mostly on things I already know how to do. - I stop when the work is hard. - I listened to feedback about my work.	- I am willing to try something new or hard when my teacher asks me to. - I ask for help when the work is hard. - I ask for feedback about my work.	- I am willing to try something new or hard. - I try to do the work several different ways before asking for help. - I use feedback to improve my work.	- I like new or challenging tasks that improve my learning. - I use strategies and resources and tried several different ways to complete the work before asking for help. - I use feedback to improve my work and the way I work. - I provide feedback to others to improve their work.
Do I take ownership of my actions?	- I make choices that are good for me. - I do what I want to do.	- I know how my choices might affect others. - I know when my choices might have consequences.	- I make choices that are good for me and others. - I know and accept the consequences of my decisions.	- I make choices that are good for me and others. - I change my actions when I make a mistake. - I anticipate the potential consequences and plan my decisions.